ABOUT THE ORIGINAL STUDY

# The Effects of the Four-Day School Week on Teacher Recruitment and Retention

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## Why It Matters

Districts increasingly adopt four-day school weeks to improve staffing. This study contrasts educator perceptions with estimates of effects on recruitment and retention in Missouri.

## Data and Sample

The study combines qualitative interviews with Missouri administrative data and difference-in-differences models. Its estimates concern Missouri districts and the adoption periods observed, not all four-day schedules nationally.

## Key Findings

- Educators interviewed generally perceived recruitment and retention benefits from four-day schedules.
- The quantitative analysis found no evidence that adoption improved teacher retention or expanded districts' teacher workforces.
- New hires shifted toward teachers with prior Missouri experience; the authors' checks suggest that null retention findings are unlikely to reflect saturation alone.

## Policy Implications

- Avoid assuming that positive educator perceptions establish staffing benefits from a four-day schedule.
- Weigh staffing claims against broader evidence on instructional time and student outcomes; this study does not estimate all benefits and costs.
- Address underlying rural staffing challenges through resources and supports, and evaluate approaches that preserve student learning.

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